American airplanes violating Cuban airspace with Soviet weapons, even if there should be an order from Fidel Castro to that effect." A day after that, Gromyko instructed Mikoyan on how to answer Cuban queries about the Soviet refusal to fire at the Americans. He was to state the following: "In view of the fact that the decision on firing at American planes was not submitted for our approval, we do not consider it possible to take part in this. For this reason, we have given instructions to our military men not to open fire on American planes."[18]

When Castro and his aides met with Mikoyan on the afternoon of November 19, the Cuban leader was as angry about the American overflights as ever. "The U-2 flights are continuing," he told Mikoyan. "They rove wherever they want." But he was no longer trying to obtain an end to overflights for the withdrawal of the bombers. He saw the writing on the wall. Speaking on his own behalf and not, as he pointed out, on behalf of the entire leadership, Castro told Mikoyan: "If we manage to obtain the lifting of the blockade at the price of withdrawing the IL-28s, that will be an important step." After a break of at least two hours for consultations with colleagues, sometime after 9:00 p.m. Castro returned to Mikoyan's residence to deliver the verdict of the entire Cuban leadership: they would consent to the withdrawal of the bombers under the terms of an agreement to be formalized in a letter to U Thant, which they discussed with Mikoyan late that night. Its key sentence read: "If the Soviet Government considers it desirable for the smooth conduct of the negotiations and the solution of the crisis to withdraw these planes, the Revolutionary Government of Cuba will not object to this decision."[19]

By the evening of November 19, Castro realized that he had lost the battle for the bombers. Over his protests, Khrushchev had decided to make a deal with the Americans. Castro was also losing the propaganda war: Latin American leaders and the world media were pointing to Cuba as the main obstacle to reaching an agreement between the two superpowers that would prevent a nuclear war. And there was one more reason for his growing concern: Kennedy's imminent press conference that was announced in the US media. He was concerned that Kennedy would attack and humiliate Cuba—"make a dirty rag out of us"—demoralizing the Cubans and probably driving them to abandon their leader. Castro played